

Socrates and the origins of moral philosophy



Statues of the classical virtues at the Musée d'Orsay, Paris.

It was not only in his methods that Socrates differed from most pre-Socratic philosophers; as an active participant in Athenian politics, he also felt that their metaphysical speculations were largely irrelevant to human life. And despite his alleged contempt for the sophists (see [The sophists and relativism](#)), Socrates was as influenced by their concentration on human concerns as he was by their methods. What interested him were concepts such as justice, virtue, courage and, above all, truth – abstract ideas

prompted by the structure of Athenian society, and what we now recognize as the concerns of moral philosophy.

In his philosophical discussions with the citizens of Athens, Socrates sought definitions for these concepts, trying to narrow down their properties by dialectical discourse and reasoning. He professed no knowledge or opinions, but his line of questioning often implied some underlying ideas of right and wrong and led the discussion to conclusions that he believed would help people to behave more morally and live a 'good life'.